

THE TV AND I: A LOVE STORY

In my house, we didn't have dinner with the TV on. There was no television set in the dining room or the kitchen. Nothing the idiot box had to offer counted as an edifying activity for my family. It ranked lower than a hobby.

Watching TV slowly became an intimate, solitary pleasure. As a little girl, on Saturdays I'd wake up very early and, with the house still dark and silent, I'd go to the kitchen, make myself a hot chocolate, and call my grandmother Julia on the phone. She was the only person who'd been up before me, and she was the one who'd given me the fourteen-inch television I kept in my bedroom — the same one I had until I moved out on my own.

I'd go back to bed with my hot chocolate and cookies and watch TV. A genuine ritual in 4:30 format that stays with me to this day. At first it was *Sailor Moon* or *Sabrina the Teenage Witch*; these days it's old episodes of *Para Vestir Santos*, or—

A few years later I'd get home from school and sit on my bed to watch my first telenovelas, sometimes with candy; I'd line the pieces up in the order I planned to eat them, from worst to best: an alfajor, a Bon o Bon, a Cabsha.

This ceremony worked as a balm for my first anxieties and first heartbreaks, a self-issued excuse for breaks from studying in school and before exams at university, the recess that was justified and could not be postponed, even many years later, when a deadline for an article was closing in or work stress was mounting.

What do these stories have that works like a haven for me? What was it in these television products that sat me down every day at the same hour in front of the television for years? Why do I still devour these misadventures episode by episode in the age of YouTube and streaming platforms? What part of my identity shows up there? Why do telenovelas taste like homeland to me?

This book is an answer to those questions, and a way of settling an outstanding debt: the one we owe to telenovelas. Those popular, underrated fictions that were mirror, company, comfort, and sentimental schooling for generations. They gave us so much, and for years — and some people, to this day — hide them at the back of the closet as if they were a shameful pleasure, something you don't say out loud.

We owe them a close reading, a political and affective one; it's time to look at them with the attention they deserve, to take them for what they are: an emotional, cultural, and political archive of the country. Defending telenovelas is also a way of vindicating discredited knowledge: gossip, the domestic, the sentimental — everything that power taught us not to take seriously.

But first I want to tell you how this love story starts, the one between telenovelas and me.

I was six years old. I caught tonsillitis and stayed home for a week. My parents had the big TV in their room, so I'd wake up and crawl into their bed. At eleven in the morning I'd watch *El Árbol Azul* on Canal Volver, a children's telenovela that had aired a few years earlier. The cast included Mónica Gonzaga, Mónica Galán, Victoria Onetto — who played the teacher — and Guido Kaczka, who led the young cast. It was also the first TV work for Belén Blanco and Facundo Espinosa. The show was about a group of preteen friends from the neighborhood and school who went through all kinds of family, economic, social, and religious conflicts, and always resolved them in the kindest, most loving way. The moral of each episode leaned fairly conservative — my progressive psychoanalyst mother would not have approved at all of the lessons in each chapter, but she had no idea I was watching it.

In the middle of that sick week I had to go to school because there was an assembly. But after playing a street vendor from 1810, I wanted to go straight back home: I convinced my mom I was still sick and crawled back into her bed to watch the telenovela. The spell was cast.

August 7, 1995, was another key day. Instituto Sarmiento in the Flores neighborhood, second period, nine-twenty in the morning, first grade, music class with teacher Silvia Vega. Sitting on the bleachers, Mercedes, Lucila, Ornella, and I were rehearsing our theory of what the big premiere of *Telefé's* new telenovela, *Chiquititas*, would be like. The debate quickly spread through the whole classroom. Some thought it would be about a group of school friends, like *Amigovios*, which had started that summer; others thought it would be more of a teen drama, like *Montaña Rusa*, a show Canal 13 had aired a couple of seasons before. But the promos playing told us it was a different universe altogether, a completely different pursuit: colors, music, choreography, looks, butterflies in your stomach. All the things I already loved at six years old.

I'd get home at 4:45 p.m., have my afternoon snack watching *Cebollitas* in the big bed, and, as night fell over my house's terrace, I'd sink into the world of *Las Rechufas* with such passion that I'd go completely still. Every now and then, between patients, my mother would appear to remind me that girls' households weren't like that: "There are no John L. Cook jumpers, no boys, no songs, no Belén Fragas." But what interested me were their feelings, their contradictions, their friendship, the ups and downs of their daily lives, how they worked through the dramas with their

absent fathers or the smallest everyday matters: their gossip. It all happened on the green quilt of my mother's bed, and it stayed with me forever as my common sense of what "domestic" looks like: today I have the same quilt, in gray, on the bed I share with my partner.

At first I devoured the kids' and teen shows: *Amigovios*, *Chiquititas*, *Cebollitas*, *Verano del 98*, *Rebelde Way*; later I discovered the afternoon telenovelas, and a few years after that I worked up the nerve for the costumbrista ones at night.

I went to school full-day, but my grandmother Julia would pick me up at noon for lunch, and at her house we'd watch *Como Pan Caliente*, the story of three women who owned a bakery. Mirta Busnelli, María Valenzuela, and Marita Ballesteros had conflicts with their children, with their husbands, and with work — never with each other. I wonder how many women actually co-owned their own businesses with other women in Argentina in those years.

I loved the shamelessness of *La Cholito*, Natalia Oreiro's character in *Muñeca Brava*, and the possibility of her love story with Facundo Arana, her wealthy, unpleasant boss — but what really hooked me was the way those families faced and worked through everyday conflicts, in the daily routine, in those small, big lives.

Then I discovered *Pol-Ka*, and, as if someone had read my heart, along came *Gasoleros*. Gossip made into a telenovela. I'd be fading with sleep at school the next day, but at nine years old something kept me glued to the television, to Silvia Montanari's kitchen, to the table with mate and tarot cards where Mercedes Morán and María Fiorentino sat.

One summer — one of those summers that felt endless, because when you're ten or eleven, December to March is an eternity — my pre-teen rebellion took the shape of staying up late. At two in the morning, Canal Volver aired *Montaña Rusa*; I'd already seen it the first time around, but watching it again now I noticed different things. The house in complete silence, and me, once again, in my bed, with my fourteen-inch TV turned nearly all the way down because the house is sleeping and because "telenovelas are trash."

I started high school in 2002, and by then many of the telenovelas we watched worked like an extension of public debate. The next day we'd talk about the latest episodes of *Resistiré*, *Padre Coraje*, *Montecristo*, or *1/2 Falta*. All of them fictions shot through with social and political debates that, without setting out to, helped build a certain sensibility about the present. There was a powerful form of cultural intervention happening there too, one that still deserves to be looked at more closely. At the same time, we stayed hooked on Cris Morena's shows, especially *Rebelde Way*, which offered a different register: teenage emotion, desire, intense friendship, color. Both

of those ways of watching, of feeling, and of thinking coexisted in me — and in many of us.

As I grew up and my life got more complicated, they — the telenovelas — were always there waiting to hold me, to tell me everything was going to be okay, that they'd always be there. Like a home. Like a mother.

...

I was already in college when *Valientes* started, a classic telenovela, a full-blown *culebrón*. It aired at 9 p.m. on Canal 13. A couple of nights a week I had evening classes at the Sociology school, so the channel's decision to put episodes online saved me. I split my time between texts by Foucault, Durkheim, and Weber, and episodes of the show, which I watched on the desktop computer with the sliding keyboard tray at my boyfriend's place at the time. When we broke up, I binged the competing show on *Telefé* instead: *Caín y Abel*.

In 2010 I landed my first serious job, at Rock and Pop, producing a show that ran from 7 to 9 p.m., but back then we'd stick around one or two extra hours just hanging out at the station. For all of us, that was our only job, and it was enough. I'd get home late, reeking of cigarette smoke and food we'd gotten through some sponsor trade-off. Sometimes I managed to talk my mom into it — she'd agree, reluctantly — and we'd watch *El Elegido* together.

When I moved out on my own, I bought myself a big TV on installments so I could watch telenovelas in peace, with the volume up loud. Because by then, in my house, telenovelas weren't a secret pleasure anymore.

...

This book is here to vindicate Argentine telenovelas, and, alongside them, gossip as a legitimate discursive genre. Because that's what telenovelas are made of: decades and decades of women at the hair salon, at the school gates, in the supermarket line, on breaks at work, in bar bathrooms, telling each other how their husbands are cheating with the neighbor and plan to keep doing it. For many, those stories of injustice are nothing more than gossip, rumor, tittle-tattle: a kind of knowledge that power discredits and devalues. And it's precisely the trivializing construction of "gossip" that has allowed men to deny and minimize those truths, to cheapen them, to invalidate a vital narrative, to turn it into some made-up version coming from someone who doesn't deserve to be taken seriously.

In women's daily lives, in their relationships and their spaces — dropping the kids off at school and, right there at the gate, debating, organizing, and sorting everything out, from the teacher's gift to a fight between kids, going to work, dealing with a macho boss, helping a friend or sister with her kids and her life, taking a mother to the doctor — just like in the telenovelas, men aren't there. That's where women are the heroines; they've always been the true subjects of the action.

Telenovelas come to say that poor people and women are more interesting than the rich, which is why their stories deserve to be told. And yet, since the presumed target audience of these soaps is women — more precisely, housewives — the academic eye skipped right over them. Since the 1940s, there have been women ironing on both sides of the screen, rethinking themselves, listening to themselves, watching themselves, and smuggling out, even if only in scraps, fragments of emancipation.

For how many women did their favorite heroine open up a new horizon of possibilities? For how many was she the first woman they ever saw walk away from an unhappy marriage, chase her own dreams, be a friend and build a network with other women, be a boss, be a leader, stand up to her employer? For how many women was Roxy, from *Gasoleros*, the first woman they ever saw fed up with an emasculated husband? A woman, fed up, on Argentine television, in 1998!

How many women may have thought for the first time that professional ambition didn't have to keep them from marriage, watching Araceli González and María Valenzuela fight for their careers in *Primicias*? In that telenovela about journalists, women's work was front and center, at a moment when gender parity in the media was less than a dream — and yet there they were, giving it their all at the newspaper *El Urbano* and the news channel TV Set.

It's true that telenovelas have, historically, offered patriarchal narratives. And yet, even within those stories there were always lines of flight, especially for women, for housewives, for the ones who in the eighties and nineties married very young, raised children, and lived out their conflicts behind closed doors. In those plots they found windows, cracks, the possibility of imagining something else. But telenovelas aren't only about women: they also build meanings around masculinity — whenever a character is set up as the leading man — and around another axis that has always run through them: friendship. Friendship between women, in particular. At a time when almost every narrative insisted that women could only be rivals to each other, telenovelas proposed something else: they showed that friendship between women wasn't just possible, but desirable, strong, and political.

The terrain of telenovelas hasn't been free of dispute. More recently, as feminism came out of the closet again in Argentina's fourth wave, some of the creators behind these shows tried to join that conversation without really taking any risks. They went looking for ways to recover the old values, and offered period telenovelas instead. In 2019, right after we'd lost the abortion vote in the Senate but won it in the streets, on social media, and at family dinner tables, Pol-Ka, in Argentina, decided to set *Tierra de Amor y Venganza* in the past — because from there, it was easier to slip in feminist winks.

Watching telenovelas is also a way of doing justice to gossip. And, deep down, to our own lives. Seventy thousand years ago, when humanity discovered the pleasure of finding out what was happening to other people, it invented language. Anyone who says they're not interested in gossip is lying. What changes is the packaging: some gossip carries more prestige than others. Political scandals seem to weigh more than a fight between a boss and a worker at the shop, but underneath it, the logic is the same: wanting to know what happened, how, when, and why someone did what they did.

Journalism and sociology: gossip careers with a method. So that's what I did: I kept watching telenovelas. Before, during, and after school, university, work, life, feminism, and the new gossip. Because if there's a literary genre truly committed to the other person, to their emotions, their conflicts, and their desires, it's this one. The most underrated, and the most honest, of them all.

. . .

I always loved love stories: the main couple's, the one that's the star of the whole solar system that makes up a soap opera — but also the others', the ones who give the protagonist someone to talk to, the friends who lead those small lives that only make sense in relation to the leading man or the heroine, the ones who pour the mate and set off an intimate conversation or a confession. In that intimacy a door opens, one that blends with my own life, in that interval, in that vigil between one episode and the next.

How much time has passed since I left Roxy chatting with Felicidad on the television in my room, to the last time I turned it back on? When was the last night I watched Sor Piedad become Baroness Manfredi and walk out my front door? How many hours separate me from the mate that Mili and Gloria share in the Di Carlo family's kitchen? Not many. Or not enough for the feeling to fade with the grind of the day.

Night after night, noon after noon, the mansion's living room carries on in my kitchen; I wash the dishes and listen to the dreamy maid's heels clicking down the carpeted stairs. I go to school, to university, to work, I run into someone, and somehow words that aren't mine come pouring out of me — they're hers.

The dreamy maid and I are friends, we talk, we share a platonic intimacy in that no-place that stretches from the tiles of the little laundry room in my old rented apartment on Yatay Street to the parquet floor of her bedroom on the Sonotex set. The one she shares with a cook who stands in as her mother, and whose own story only exists so the dreamy maid can tell hers.

Gossip made into television, once again. That narrative so thoroughly dismissed by academia, that lesser knowledge, hair-salon stories, the goings-on of Doña Rosa, the intimacy of nobodies. The very thing that, to this day, moves me in equal measure whether it's about whoever's running the destiny of the nation, or about the friend of the friend of a friend.

Welcome to the next chapter.